

Our worth isn't defined by what we buy for other people

On a related note, this issue – how our sense of worth is sometimes linked to our buying power in relation to others – is a big one for me. There is an assumption among a lot of people that emotional spending and living beyond your means is a purely selfish thing. And while I'm sure that this is the case for some, I would like to politely call bullshit, because I think they are a minority. Most people I know tend to spend in response to some kind of pull on their heartstrings.

When I finished paying off my debt and suddenly had a lot more money available to me, my first thought wasn't about what goal I should be focussing on now – it was about who I could buy things for. How I could make up for money being so tight over the previous few years by showing people that I cared in the way that I've been taught to show them – by buying them things.

Generosity is a truly wonderful quality, and one that I think is sometimes undervalued, but there is something flawed in the way that we view generosity in today's society. More often than not, we are encouraged to see generosity – both other people's and our own – in relation to its cash value. This is often exacerbated around gift-giving season, and particularly Christmas, but it exists all year round. I've certainly been guilty in the past of disregarding acts of kindness and generosity that didn't manifest in the form of desirable objects, of being